

INDIA TODAY was planned as a fortnightly.

We were ready to launch on December 15, 1975. There was just one problem: India was under the iron-fisted Emergency. In retrospect, it seemed suicidal to launch a newsmagazine under Goebbelsian censorship rules. Madhu, then editor, carried prints of all the stories to the censor's office where bureaucrats armed with blue pencils would scan every word for anything 'objectionable'. She returned with surprisingly few blue pencil marks, despite our first cover story being titled: 'The Emergency: Now You See It, Now You Don't'. In an ironic but fortuitous twist of fate, we were banned from selling it abroad, so copies of the first issue were diverted to the Indian market. It was, in journalistic terms, the proverbial throw of the dice, but there was no turning back. It was, in Dickensian language, the worst of times.

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Yet, we forged ahead and also started holding our editorial meetings in the Press Club, a vibrant members-only oasis where you could express yourself freely without being hauled off to prison. There we heard inside stories of the dark side of the Emergency from journalists whose colleagues, family members and non-Congress political contacts had been jailed or tortured. In a very short space of time, INDIA TODAY as a calling card was granting us accessibility and credibility. By the time the Emergency was lifted, after 17 months of a media clampdown, the magazine had expanded, in pages and circulation numbers. In terms of writing style and